



POLITICS OF TERROR

■ By Bhavna Vij-Aurora

When Railways Minister and key UPA ally Lalu Prasad Yadav went to meet Sonia Gandhi last week, demanding the removal of Shivraj Patil as home minister, it was with his characteristic bluster. However, when he came out, Lalu was considerably chastened and had lowered his anti-Patil pitch. The UPA chairperson had politely, but very firmly, reminded him about his very vocal and public sup-

port for the Students' Islamic Movement of India (SIMI) earlier. He could not support the outfit one day and then criticise the home minister for not being able to control terror perpetrated by its members. "For once Lalu was left floundering for words. Madam told him not to politicise the issue and pipe down on Patil's criticism. So he changed tracks and instead focused on intelligence failure," disclosed a senior Congress leader.

The Lalu-Sonia face-off may not have helped the real issue but it definitely highlighted two major problems which come in the way of tackling terrorism in the country—the political imperatives and the failure of intelligence agencies. Lalu's Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) was not the only party which came out in support of SIMI. UPA's other allies, Ram Vilas Paswan of Lok Janshakti Party (LJP) and newfound friend Mulayam Singh Yadav of the Samajwadi Party (SP) had joined Lalu in their unstinted support of

SIMI, an outfit which has been responsible for carrying out all major bombings in the past few years. The outfit is the backbone of Indian terrorism, a organisation which has been responsible for all major recent terror attacks.

In fact, Paswan was suggesting that all Bangladeshis granted Indian citizenship in forthcoming elections be checked by a strict vetting process. Those who had made it through would be welcomed with open arms as "good people". This despite the fact that the outfit has been based in the region since 1989 (HUJI)—along with Lashkar-e-Taiba suspected to be providing

Sonia told Lalu Prasad that HE COULD NOT support SIMI one day and ask for the HOME MINISTER'S head the next.